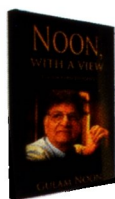


High Noon

The life and turbulent times of the tycoon who is Britain's curry King



NOON, WITH A VIEW

by GULAM NOON
Penguin Enterprise
Price: Rs 499
Pages: 200

| By Dilip Bobb |

Enter a Sainsbury's in the UK and one of the most prominent items on display will be the packaged Indian meals stamped Noon Products. They are made in an ultra-modern factory in London's Southall built by Gulam Noon, or Sir Gulam Noon as he is official titled in the UK where he made his name and considerable fortune.

His is the classic rags to riches story. Rags is an exaggeration but it was certainly humble: his family came from a small town in Rajasthan and he grew up in Mumbai. Today, he is one of Britain's most successful entrepreneurs with a multi-million pound food business which earned him the sobriquet of 'Curry King'. Noon was singularly responsible for turning chicken tikka masala into Britain's national dish, was knighted by the Queen, lists Tony Blair and Gordon Brown as friends, meets regularly with Prince Charles for his charities and London's rich and famous are all on his speed dial.

This autobiography is bookended by two life-changing events. It opens with Noon, as he is popularly known, being prime accused in the cash-for-peerage scandal that rocked Tony Blair's New Labour government in 2006. He was eventually exonerated but it tarred his reputation. The book ends with a far more harrowing experience: being trapped in the Taj hotel in Mumbai during 26/11. He escaped and the first person to dial his mobile was Prime Minister Brown. Noon's description of the two events and their impact on his life are riveting enough. He devotes a large portion of the book to the British

SAURABH SINGH

political system and its flaws and advantages, as he does with other aspects of British life as seen through the eyes of a budding entrepreneur, an immigrant from India, and a Muslim. As in all success stories, the saga of his rise and the expansion of his empire offers, in his case, food for thought. Yet, as in all success stories, it is as much luck: being in the right place at the right time with the right product.

Shopping for Indian packaged food in his initial years in London, he is upset by how bland and badly packed the boil-in-a-bag products are. He describes this as his 'Eureka!' moment and his decision to mortgage his house and produce Indian packaged food of restaurant quality for UK supermarkets leads to fortune. He starts with three dishes and finding that one, chicken makhanwala, is literally a mouthful, changes the name to chicken tikka masala. The rest is history. It was 1989 and the start of Britain's love affair with Indian food. In 2006, Noon products had a turnover of £150 million. What adds value is

Noon's views on sensitive issues like immigration, terrorism and Muslims in Britain. He has strong views on terrorism and how warped religion and faith taught in Britain's madrasas and mosques by radical mullahs mixed with the British obsession with human rights and being politically correct is making it easier to produce recruits for global terrorism. This is a book rich in anecdotes, experience and commentary, brutally frank but interesting and provocative.

Noon has sold his food business but is still involved in enterprises, some in India. Semi-retirement offers time to indulge in his other passion, cricket, and more visits to India. To devote as much effort to philanthropy as to his businesses takes a rare commitment and this autobiography may yet have an epilogue. At 73, he admits that he still has "fire in the belly" and it may not yet be high noon for the Noon Empire. ■



MUSHARRAF: THE YEARS IN POWER

by MURTAZA RAZVI
HarperCollins India
Price: Rs 399
Pages: 233

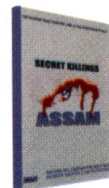
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